# Real-World Applications of RSA: Cryptographic Foundations, Practical Implementation, and Off-Chain Blockchain Authentication

*Academic Research Paper in Cryptography, Cybersecurity, and Blockchain Systems*

**Abstract—** The RSA cryptosystem remains a foundational pillar of modern public-key cryptography. While public blockchain consensus protocols predominantly utilize elliptic-curve cryptography (ECC) for on-chain state compactness, RSA plays an enduring role in enterprise infrastructure, Public Key Infrastructure (PKI), and internal gateway authorization. This report provides an academic investigation of real-world RSA applications across theory, operational justification, and systems engineering. We formulate RSA's mathematical foundations, contrasting RSA-OAEP key transport with RSA-PSS digital signatures (WHAT). We analyze why RSA is favored in specific trust architectures, providing an evidence-based comparison against ECDSA and Schnorr signatures (WHY). Finally, we design, implement, and benchmark an educational off-chain cryptocurrency withdrawal authentication system using RSA-PSS and SHA-256 (HOW). Empirical benchmarks across RSA (2048, 3072, 4096 bits) and ECDSA (secp256k1) on identical hardware demonstrate RSA's distinct operational profile: while RSA signing is slower than ECDSA, RSA public exponent verification (e = 65,537) executes significantly faster across all tested key sizes—RSA-2048 is 13.45x faster, RSA-3072 is 8.22x faster, and RSA-4096 is 5.4x faster than ECDSA verification. At the approximately equivalent 128-bit classical security level (RSA-3072 vs. ECDSA-secp256k1), RSA-3072 verification is 8.22x faster than ECDSA, whereas ECDSA signing is 3.87x faster than RSA-3072. Adversarial security scenario testing demonstrates that combining cryptographic digital signatures with application-level timestamp freshness and nonce replay caches significantly strengthens request authentication against payload tampering and replay attacks. Evaluation against the bundled RSA-PSS 2048-bit SHA-256/MGF1-SHA256 Wycheproof test-vector set (version 0.9 snapshot, 108 cases) confirms that the verification engine correctly accepts all 63 expected-valid test cases and rejects all 45 expected-invalid test cases, validating execution against this selected verification suite.

**Keywords:** *RSA Cryptography, RSA-PSS, Digital Signatures, PKI, Hybrid Encryption, Cryptocurrency Security, Off-chain Authentication, Empirical Evaluation.*

## 1. Introduction and Research Scope

First documented by Ron Rivest, Adi Shamir, and Leonard Adleman in their April 1977 MIT research memorandum and published in Communications of the ACM in 1978 [1], and formally standardized under PKCS #1 / RFC 8017 [2], the RSA cryptosystem helped address the historic key distribution challenge by separating the private transformation used for decryption and signing from the public transformation used for encryption and verification. Although asymmetric cryptography eliminates the requirement for secret symmetric key pre-distribution, it does not remove the necessity for authentic public-key distribution, requiring Public Key Infrastructure (PKI), certificate authorities, or trusted directories to prevent impersonation. For nearly five decades, RSA has underpinned digital commerce, software distribution, and enterprise identity management.

In modern blockchain environments, architectural debate centers on cryptographic algorithm selection. Major public networks—including Bitcoin and Ethereum—rely on Elliptic Curve Cryptography (ECC) for native on-chain transaction signatures [8], [12], [13]. In enterprise cryptocurrency operations, transaction handling does not occur solely on-chain; systems employ layered off-chain microservices, hardware security modules (HSMs), and Transport Layer Security (TLS 1.3) tunnels [3] to authenticate and authorize requests before dispatching them to blockchain nodes. This report investigates real-world RSA applications across three dimensions: (1) WHAT: mathematical principles and operational distinctions between RSA-OAEP key transport and RSA-PSS signatures; (2) WHY: security justification of RSA and an evidence-based comparison with ECDSA and Schnorr; (3) HOW: practical design, implementation, and empirical evaluation of an educational off-chain cryptocurrency withdrawal authentication system using RSA-PSS.

## 2. RSA Fundamentals and Real-World Applications

### 2.1 Mathematical Foundations and Operating Mechanics

The security of RSA rests on the presumed computational intractability of the integer factorization problem and the RSA problem [1], [2]. Given modulus $n = p \cdot q$ (where p and q are large prime numbers), factoring n immediately reveals Euler's totient $\varphi(n) = (p - 1)(q - 1)$, enabling the derivation of private exponent $d \equiv e^{-1} \pmod{\varphi(n)}$. The RSA problem asks to compute plaintext m given ciphertext $c \equiv m^e \pmod{n}$, public exponent e, and modulus n without knowing the prime factors. While an efficient factoring algorithm immediately breaks RSA, whether the RSA inversion problem is strictly equivalent to integer factorization remains an unproven hypothesis in complexity theory. In practical operations: (i) public exponent e is chosen coprime to $\varphi(n)$, typically the fourth Fermat prime $e = 65{,}537 = 2^{16} + 1$; (ii) private exponent d satisfies $e \cdot d \equiv 1 \pmod{\varphi(n)}$; and (iii) Chinese Remainder Theorem (CRT) parameters (p, q, dP, dQ, qInv) are retained to accelerate private-key operations. By Euler's theorem, for any message m coprime to n, $m^{(e \cdot d)} \equiv m \pmod{n}$. Textbook RSA operates directly on integers ($c = m^e \bmod n$; $m = c^d \bmod n$), but exhibits dangerous algebraic homomorphic properties vulnerable to chosen-ciphertext attacks. Production deployments mandate modern randomized padding schemes.

### 2.2 Distinction Between RSA Encryption and RSA Digital Signatures

RSA supports two distinct operational primitives with contrasting security goals:

• Asymmetric Encryption and Key Transport (Confidentiality): RSA-OAEP (RFC 8017 Section 7.1 [2]) provides provable semantic security. In the Random Oracle Model (ROM), Bellare and Rogaway (EUROCRYPT '94, published 1995 [17]) introduced OAEP and proved semantic security against chosen-plaintext attacks (IND-CPA) and plaintext awareness (implying IND-CCA1 for general trapdoor permutations). Shoup (CRYPTO 2001, Journal of Cryptology 2002 [15]) subsequently showed that a general IND-CCA2 proof cannot be established for arbitrary permutations under standard one-wayness, proposing the OAEP+ variant. Fujisaki, Okamoto, Pointcheval, and Stern (CRYPTO 2001, Journal of Cryptology 2004 [16]) established that RSA-OAEP achieves IND-CCA2 security in the ROM under the standard RSA assumption, introducing the concept of partial-domain one-wayness and demonstrating its equivalence to full-domain one-wayness for the RSA permutation, though the concrete reduction is non-tight for practical RSA parameters. Because RSAES-OAEP payload size is bounded by mLen <= k - 2hLen - 2 (RFC 8017 Section 7.1.1; 190 bytes for RSA-2048 with SHA-256), industrial systems deploy RSA-OAEP within hybrid encryption for RSA key transport (NIST SP 800-56B Rev. 2 [5])—encapsulating ephemeral symmetric keys to protect bulk data encrypted via symmetric ciphers such as AES-GCM (NIST SP 800-38D [22]).

• Digital Signatures (Authenticity, Integrity, Non-Repudiation Evidence): Under RFC 8017 Section 8.1 and NIST FIPS 186-5 [2],

[4], RSA-PSS is the standardized digital signature scheme. SHA-256 maps an arbitrary-length input message to a fixed-length 256-bit digest. RSA-PSS incorporates this digest into its encoding process, together with a randomized salt, before applying the RSA private-key operation. In the signing flow, the message digest mHash = SHA-256(M) and a randomized salt are encoded via EMSA-PSS into an octet string EM, converted to integer representative m = OS2IP(EM), and signed via private exponentiation s = RSASP1(SK, m) = m^d mod n. During verification, the verifier computes recovered representative m = RSAVP1(PK, s) = s^e mod n, formats octets EM = I2OSP(m, emLen), and executes EMSA-PSS-VERIFY(M, EM, emBits). Crucially, modular exponentiation (RSAVP1) alone does not establish signature validity; complete EMSA-PSS verification—unmasking the salt via MGF1, checking padding octets, and verifying hash consistency—is indispensable. RSA-PSS achieves an essentially tight security reduction to the RSA problem in the ROM (RFC 8017 [2]). Signatures provide mathematical non-repudiation evidence, while comprehensive non-repudiation requires identity binding, audit trails, and secure key custody.

• Cryptographic Key Separation (NIST FIPS 186-5 Section 5.1 / SP 800-57): Strict key separation is a core security mandate. NIST FIPS 186-5 [4] explicitly requires that an RSA key pair designated for digital signatures shall not be used for key establishment or encryption (such as RSA-OAEP). Multi-purpose key reuse exposes systems to cross-protocol chosen-ciphertext attacks, complicates non-repudiation auditing, and expands the compromise blast radius. Systems utilizing both signing and encryption must enforce distinct key pairs, separate certificate hierarchies, and independent key-management policies.

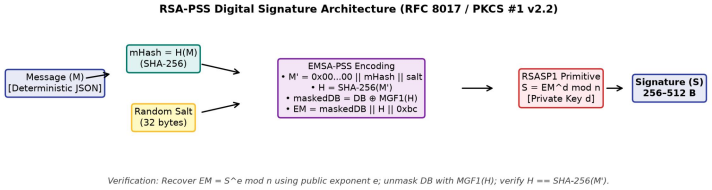



*Figure 1. Operational workflow of the RSA-PSS probabilistic digital signature scheme (RFC 8017 / FIPS 186-5).*

### 2.3 Real-World Application Breadth

In industrial systems, RSA is deployed across three primary operational domains: (1) Hybrid Encryption and Key Transport: Rather than encrypting bulk data directly, RSA-OAEP is deployed for key transport—securely transporting ephemeral symmetric keys (e.g., 256-bit AES-GCM [22] per NIST SP 800-56B Rev. 2 [5]) to combine asymmetric key establishment with high-throughput symmetric transmission. (2) Code Signing and Firmware Integrity: Operating systems, application ecosystems, and secure bootloaders widely utilize RSA digital signatures (both RSA-PSS and legacy PKCS#1 v1.5) to verify executable integrity before launch. (3) Digital Certificates and PKI: In TLS 1.3 (RFC 9846 [3], superseding RFC 8446), static RSA key exchange was removed to ensure forward secrecy through ephemeral Diffie-Hellman ((EC)DHE). To prepare for post-quantum threats, RFC 10024 [19] defines hybrid key agreement combining post-quantum mechanisms (ML-KEM) with traditional ECDHE. Consequently, RSA's modern role in TLS 1.3 is focused on endpoint authentication: RSA X.509 certificates authenticate servers via RSA-PSS CertificateVerify messages (RFC 9846 [3]). RFC 9963 [18] defines a restricted legacy exception permitting client certificate authentication using RSASSA-PKCS1-v1_5 in constrained environments, but does not permit PKCS#1 v1.5 for server authentication.

## 3. Why RSA? Security Purpose and Comparative Evaluation

RSA addresses the core security objectives of information assurance: confidentiality (via hybrid key transport), entity authentication, data integrity, and non-repudiation evidence. Table 1 compares RSA with elliptic curve alternatives: ECDSA (secp256k1) [12], [13], Schnorr (BIP 340) [8], and Ed25519 [11], with security strengths benchmarked according to NIST SP 800-56B Rev. 2 (Table 2 and Appendix D) [5] and generic elliptic-curve strength mappings from NIST SP 800-57 Part 1 Rev. 5 [6].

| Evaluation Metric | RSA-2048 | RSA-3072 | ECDSA (secp256k1) | Schnorr (BIP 340) | Ed25519 (RFC 8032) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Hard Problem | Factoring | Factoring | EC Discrete Log | EC Discrete Log | Edwards EC-DLOG |
| Security Strength | 112 bits [5] | 128 bits [5] | ~128 bits (generic EC mapping [6]) | 128 bits (generic EC mapping [6]) | 128 bits (generic EC mapping [6]) |
| Key Size / Sig Size | Modulus: 256 B<br>Sig: 256 B<br>DER PubKey: ~294 B | Modulus: 384 B<br>Sig: 384 B<br>DER PubKey: ~422 B | PubKey: 33 B (comp)<br>Bitcoin: 70–72 B (71 B sample)<br>Ethereum: 65 B (r‖s‖v), RLP; 64 B (ERC-2098) | PubKey: 32 B (x-only)<br>BIP341: 64 B (DEFAULT) or 65 B (explicit sighash) | PubKey: 32 B<br>Sig: 64 B [11] |
| Relative Verify Speed | Empirical: 0.046 ms (13.45x vs ECDSA) | Empirical: 0.076 ms (8.22x vs ECDSA) | Empirical: 0.621 ms (Baseline: 1.0x) | Batch verify supported; not benchmarked [8] | High efficiency in lit. [11]; not benchmarked |

*Table 1. Systematic comparison of asymmetric cryptographic algorithms across security and operational metrics.*

### 3.1 Storage and Verification Trade-Offs in Blockchain Consensus Layers

A primary requirement of public blockchain networks is minimizing ledger bloat and transmission overhead, as transaction fees penalize large data footprints. In Bitcoin, fees depend on transaction virtual size (vSize in vB) under BIP 141 (Segregated Witness) [9], calculated as Weight = (Base Size * 3) + Total Size and vSize = ceil(Weight / 4). A standard 1-input, 2-output SegWit P2WPKH transaction has a baseline virtual size of ~141 vB. The standard P2WPKH witness stack consists of 1 byte for the stack item count, 1 byte for the signature length prefix, approximately 71–73 bytes for the signature witness item (comprising a ~70–72 byte DER-encoded ECDSA signature plus 1 sighash byte), 1 byte for the public key length prefix, and 33 bytes for the compressed public key, yielding a total witness of 1 + 1 + (71–73) + 1 + 33 = 107–109 bytes [12]. In a hypothetical transaction model utilizing RSA-2048 for native authorization—under the simplified assumption of a 256-byte modulus payload (treating public exponent e = 65,537 as implicit or fixed, rather than complete DER-encoded public-key structures which span ~294 bytes) and a 256-byte RSA signature, each with a 3-byte CompactSize length prefix—the witness stack would expand to 1 + 3 + 256 + 3 + 256 = 519 bytes. This would add approximately 410–412 witness bytes per input, contributing ~103 additional virtual bytes under BIP 141 rules. For a 141-vB transaction, this represents an approximate 73% increase in virtual size (to ~244 vB), proportionally inflating transaction fees. Crucially, native Bitcoin RSA verification is not supported under consensus rules; this hypothetical comparison demonstrates

why blockchains favor compact elliptic curve primitives. Similarly, native Ethereum transactions require 65-byte ECDSA signatures (r, s, v) over secp256k1 [13]. While Ethereum smart contracts can execute raw modular exponentiation via the EVM precompile at address 0x05 (EIP-198), full RSA-PSS verification requires substantial contract bytecode to execute MGF1 masking, extract the salt, and verify hash consistency. Furthermore, BIP 340 Schnorr signatures [8] integrated via Taproot allow 64-byte signatures with 32-byte public keys and support signature aggregation via MuSig2 (BIP 327 [10]), allowing multiple signers to produce a single compact on-chain signature—a capability unattainable with RSA.

### 3.2 The Operational Value of RSA in Off-Chain Systems

Despite on-chain storage limitations, RSA offers distinct operational advantages in off-chain exchange backends: (1) Asymmetric Verification Efficiency: RSA public verification using exponent $e = 65{,}537 = 2^{16} + 1$ executes in only 17 modular operations (16 squarings and 1 multiplication) under binary square-and-multiply exponentiation, enabling extremely rapid verification at edge gateways. (2) Enterprise Infrastructure: Enterprise banking backends, payment gateways, and hardware security modules (HSMs) possess mature, highly optimized cryptographic acceleration for RSA. (3) Nonce Reuse Hazards in ECDSA: Standard ECDSA is exceptionally vulnerable to nonce failure: reusing a per-message nonce k or introducing slight bit bias completely exposes the private signing key. In contrast, RSA-PSS signature generation does not rely on a secret scalar nonce, mitigating catastrophic scalar leakage. However, RSA implementations face distinct side-channel and fault-injection vulnerabilities that require rigorous defense: (i) Bellcore CRT Fault Attacks: Accelerating RSA signing via the Chinese Remainder Theorem (CRT) is vulnerable to fault injection (Boneh et al. [7]). If a hardware fault corrupts one CRT branch (e.g., modulo q while modulo p remains intact), the resulting faulty signature s' can reveal the prime factors of the modulus. In the two-signature formulation, computing $\gcd(s - s', n) = p$ requires that both the valid signature s and faulty signature s' were computed over the exact same encoded representative $m = \text{OS2IP}(EM)$. Because RSA-PSS introduces a randomized salt during encoding, independent signing operations on the same message M yield different encoded representatives ($EM_1 \neq EM_2$); thus, two independently generated signatures do not satisfy this condition. In the single-fault formulation, an attacker who knows the exact encoded representative m used in the faulty execution can factor n via $\gcd((s')^e - m, n) = p$; however, this requires knowledge of the specific randomized representative of that execution. (ii) Defense Differentiation: RSA base blinding (randomizing the base integer $x' = x \cdot r^e \bmod n$ with secret factor r) effectively mitigates timing side-channel attacks by decoupling operation timing from secret key bits. Crucially, base blinding does not prevent CRT fault injection. Defending against CRT fault injection mandates post-computation verification (verifying that $s^e \bmod n$ matches the encoded representative before releasing the signature) or redundant fault-detection hardware circuitry.

## 4. Proposed System Design and Implementation

We design an off-chain architecture: Using RSA-PSS Digital Signatures to Authenticate Off-Chain Withdrawal Requests in Cryptocurrency Exchanges. Architectural Boundary: The proposed architecture operates strictly off-chain within an internal exchange authorization boundary to authenticate withdrawal requests before they reach hot-wallet signers; it does not replace on-chain consensus signatures, nor does it represent the proprietary architecture of any specific commercial platform.

### 4.1 Architecture and Component Decomposition

As illustrated in Figure 2, the conceptual authentication pipeline decouples request origination from on-chain broadcast across four components: (1) Withdrawal Service (Frontend): Formats the withdrawal request: blockchain network, recipient address, withdrawal amount (in exact integer atomic units, e.g., wei), a UUIDv4 nonce, and a UNIX epoch timestamp. (2) RSA Signing Component: Conceptually hosted within a secure service boundary, this component formats the payload using deterministic JSON serialization, computes the SHA-256 digest, and signs the request using the exchange private key via RSA-PSS. (3) Verification Gateway: An edge gateway that receives the payload and signature, retrieves the authorized RSA public key, reconstructs the message digest, and validates the RSA-PSS signature. (4) Request Validation Engine: Enforces stateful application rules: checks timestamp freshness (±300s window) and verifies nonce uniqueness against a replay cache. Crucially, the signature authenticates the integrity of the request within the internal service boundary, establishing that the payload originated from an authorized signing component.

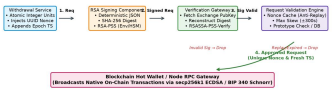



*Figure 2. Proposed off-chain cryptocurrency withdrawal authentication architecture using RSA-PSS.*

### 4.2 Deterministic JSON Serialization and Pipeline Algorithm

Cryptographic signature verification fails if distributed services serialize JSON whitespace or key ordering inconsistently. Our system implements deterministic JSON serialization by lexicographically sorting keys, eliminating non-essential whitespace, and encoding to UTF-8. While inspired by canonical formatting, this custom serialization does not implement full RFC 8785 (which requires ECMAScript number formatting and UTF-16 code unit ordering); it provides deterministic byte-level consistency for the defined schema. Per RFC 8017 Section 9.1, EMSA-PSS encoding specifies emBits = modBits − 1 so that integer representative m = OS2IP(EM) satisfies m < n. For a 2048-bit modulus, emBits = 2047 bits (emLen = 256 bytes), with salt length constrained by sLen <= emLen − hLen − 2 (sLen <= 222 bytes for SHA-256; our pipeline uses sLen = 32 bytes). Algorithm 1 details the complete verification lifecycle.

```
Algorithm 1: Off-Chain Withdrawal Authentication Pipeline
Input:  Request R = {id, net, addr, amt_atomic, nonce, ts}, Private Key SK_rsa, Public Key PK_rsa
Output: Decision ∈ {ACCEPT, REJECT_SIG, REJECT_REPLAY, REJECT_EXPIRED}
1:  M_canon ← DeterministicJSON(R)                    // Lexicographical keys, compact separators, UTF-8
2:  EM ← EMSA-PSS-ENCODE(M_canon, emBits=modBits-1, sLen=32) // RFC 8017 PSS encoding
3:  σ ← RSASP1(SK_rsa, OS2IP(EM))                     // Signature generation
4:  // Gateway Verification Phase
5:  valid_sig ← RSASSA-PSS-Verify(PK_rsa, M_canon, σ, SHA-256, sLen=32)
6:  if ¬ valid_sig then return REJECT_SIG               // Tampering detected
7:  if |CurrentTime() − R.ts| > Δ_skew then return REJECT_EXPIRED
8:  if R.nonce ∈ NonceStore then return REJECT_REPLAY     // Replay detected
9:  NonceStore.Add(R.nonce); return ACCEPT
```

### 4.3 Prototype Scope and Vital Security Considerations

To ensure academic integrity, the educational prototype must be clearly distinguished from production exchange requirements: (1) Address Validation: The prototype performs an elementary sanity check (verifying that the recipient address string is non-empty and has a minimum length of 10 characters). It does not validate a 0x prefix, hexadecimal encoding, Ethereum EIP-55 checksums, or Bitcoin Bech32/Bech32m formats; production systems require full chain-specific address decoding and checksum verification. (2) Public-Key Management: The prototype generates an RSA-2048 keypair in memory and passes the public-key object directly to the verifier. It does not implement persistent key provisioning, certificate authorities, PKI path validation, CRL/OCSP revocation checking, or automated key rotation, which remain mandatory production requirements. (3) Private-Key Custody: The prototype stores signing keys in volatile process memory for educational demonstration, whereas production architectures mandate appropriately validated HSMs (e.g., FIPS 140-3) or secure enclaves. (4) Stateful Replay Prevention: The prototype tracks nonces using an in-memory Python set without distributed concurrency guarantees. Production deployments require persistent, distributed, atomic check-and-insert mechanisms (e.g., Redis SETNX or SQL unique constraint transactions) with TTL expiration. (5) Identity and Authorization Boundary: Crucially, the RSA signature does not independently prove the identity of the end customer, nor does it establish that the customer is authorized to withdraw funds. The signature verifies only that the request was signed by the holder of the private key and that the payload has not been altered in transit. Customer authentication (MFA/OAuth), account authorization, ledger balance verification, withdrawal limits, and AML compliance remain distinct application-tier responsibilities.

## 5. Experimental Results and Analysis

The system was evaluated using Python 3.15 and cryptography v50.0.2 (OpenSSL 4.0.3) on an AMD Ryzen 5 7520U processor (4 cores, 8 threads @ 2.80 GHz) running Windows 11. High-resolution timings were captured using time.perf_counter_ns() across 10 key-generation trials and 100 signature generation and verification trials per algorithm (840 raw measurements total). All RSA key sizes (2048, 3072, 4096 bits) and ECDSA (secp256k1) were evaluated under identical conditions.

### 5.1 Adversarial Security Testing Scenarios

Execution of rsa_pss_experiment.py confirmed all five target operational security scenarios: (1) Scenario 1 (Authentic Request): Valid request (12.5 ETH atomic units) -> ACCEPTED; (2) Scenario 2 (Tampered Amount): Payload altered to 50.0 ETH; signature verification returned False -> REJECTED; (3) Scenario 3 (Tampered Recipient): Recipient address altered; signature verification failed -> REJECTED; (4) Scenario 4 (Rogue Public Key): Signature evaluated against an unauthorized RSA public key -> REJECTED; (5) Scenario 5 (Replay Attack): Resubmitted request passed cryptographic signature verification, but duplicate nonce was intercepted -> REJECTED BY APPLICATION STATE ENGINE.

### 5.2 Bundled Wycheproof Test Suite Validation

To evaluate implementation compliance against authoritative test vectors, the test harness executed the bundled RSA-PSS 2048-bit SHA-256/MGF1-SHA256 Wycheproof test set (version 0.9 snapshot, 108 test cases) [14]. The verification engine passed all 108 cases with 100% agreement (0 failures), correctly accepting all 63 expected-valid signatures and rejecting all 45 expected-invalid signatures (including corrupted salts, altered padding, and tampered public keys), validating execution against this selected verification suite.

### 5.3 Empirical Benchmarking and Performance Analysis

Table 2 reports empirical benchmark measurements comparing RSA configurations with ECDSA (secp256k1).

*Table 2. Empirical benchmark measurements (AMD Ryzen 5 7520U, Python 3.15, OpenSSL 4.0.3, median of 10 keygen / 100 crypto trials).*

| Algorithm | Security Level | Keygen Median | Sign Median | Verify Median | Sig Size | Internal Asymmetry |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| RSA-2048 | 112 bits [5] | 50.0708 ms | 0.9005 ms | 0.0462 ms | 256 B | 19.49x (Sign / Verify) |
| RSA-3072 | 128 bits [5] | 253.9132 ms | 2.7834 ms | 0.0756 ms | 384 B | 36.82x (Sign / Verify) |
| RSA-4096 | 152 bits [5] | 633.0616 ms | 6.5425 ms | 0.115 ms | 512 B | 56.89x (Sign / Verify) |
| ECDSA-secp256k1 | ~128 bits [6] | 0.7158 ms | 0.7196 ms | 0.6214 ms | 71 B (DER sample) | 1.16x (Sign / Verify) |

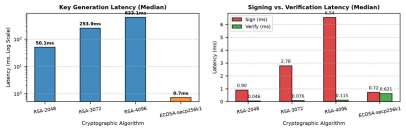



*Figure 3. Empirical median latency comparison for RSA and ECDSA key generation, signing, and verification.*

The empirical measurements demonstrate three decisive performance characteristics:

1. RSA Asymmetric Cost Structure: RSA displays a pronounced internal asymmetry: verification is 19.49x (RSA-2048) to 56.89x (RSA-4096) faster than its own signing operation. Because public exponent e = 65,537 = $2^{16}$ + 1 contains only two non-zero bits, straightforward square-and-multiply exponentiation executes in 16 squarings and 1 multiplication (17 operations total), whereas private exponent d requires full modular exponentiation.
2. Comparison with ECDSA: Comparing equivalent 128-bit classical security levels (RSA-3072 vs. ECDSA-secp256k1), ECDSA signing is 3.87x faster (0.7196 ms vs 2.7834 ms), and ECDSA key generation is over 354.7x faster (0.7158 ms vs 253.9132 ms). Conversely, RSA-3072 signature verification (0.0756 ms) is 8.22x faster than ECDSA verification (0.6214 ms). While RSA-2048 verification (0.0462 ms) is 13.45x faster and RSA-4096 (0.115 ms) is 5.4x faster than ECDSA, these represent 112-bit and 152-bit security levels. The recorded ECDSA DER signature sample was 71 bytes, generally varying between 70 and 72 bytes due to variable-length ASN.1 INTEGER encoding.
3. Isolated Latency vs Gateway Throughput: At 0.0756 ms per verification, a single CPU core can theoretically evaluate ~13,227 RSA-3072 signatures per second (vs ~1,609 for ECDSA). These figures represent isolated cryptographic operation timings, not an end-to-end exchange gateway throughput benchmark; real-world system throughput is bounded by network I/O, database persistence, and TLS handshakes.

## 6. Conclusion

This research examined the cryptographic foundations, operational trade-offs, and practical deployment of RSA in modern security architectures. While elliptic-curve cryptography (ECDSA and Schnorr) rightfully dominates public blockchain consensus layers due to compact public keys and signatures that minimize transaction virtual size (reducing Bitcoin miner fees) and storage serialization (reducing Ethereum transaction gas overhead), RSA serves distinct architectural domains. RSA remains a supported cryptographic option in enterprise PKI and can be deployed in selected off-chain authentication systems, particularly where legacy interoperability and asymmetric verification throughput are advantageous. Our educational prototype confirmed that RSA-PSS with SHA-256 provides verifiable message integrity with rapid gateway verification. However, cryptographic digital signatures alone do not guarantee complete system security; robust authorization requires defense-in-depth across deterministic serialization, stateful replay prevention, secure key custody (HSM storage), and transport encryption (TLS 1.3).

At an approximately equivalent 128-bit classical security strength, RSA-3072 provides robust resistance against conventional mathematical cryptanalysis, though it incurs substantially larger key and signature footprints than 256-bit elliptic curves. Looking toward future cryptographic horizons, RSA-PSS is vulnerable to polynomial-time integer factorization via Shor's algorithm on fault-tolerant quantum computers, as is standard elliptic-curve cryptography under discrete logarithm quantum attacks. Consequently, organizations deploying RSA-3072 today must maintain crypto-agility and prepare migration pathways toward standardized post-quantum digital signature algorithms, including NIST FIPS 204 (ML-DSA) [20] and FIPS 205 (SLH-DSA) [21].

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